They Click on a Loan Ad and Get Robbed with Meta's help

INVESTIGATIVE REPORT

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They Click on a Loan Ad and Get Robbed with Meta's help

How a network of fake Facebook pages steals money from Bangladesh's poorest — and how the platform's own machinery helps

By Miraz Hossain and Ferdous Hasan Hridoy

On a Friday afternoon in late July, Ayman Mahmud's mother was scrolling through Facebook when a video stopped her thumb. Shaikh Ahmadullah — one of Bangladesh's most trusted Islamic scholars — appeared to be endorsing a loan service. The branding looked legitimate: "Islamic Loan," it said, with a clean website and a promise of 30,000 taka, no collateral. For a family trying to scrape together coaching fees for a younger son's university admission, it felt like a door opening.

She clicked. She entered her details. She paid 3,000 taka in "security money." A text message arrived confirming that 33,000 taka had been deposited into her bKash account. When she opened the app to check, the balance was zero. The SMS had been spoofed. The page that had taken her money was already gone.

"The video was AI-generated," Ayman, a student at the University of Dhaka, said. "It wasn't from Shaikh Ahmadullah's foundation. It wasn't from any real page. But my mother — she trusts him. So she trusted it."

The Mahmuds lost 3,000 taka. In a country where 18.7 percent of the population lives below the national poverty line, that is not a rounding error. It can be groceries for a month, or the difference between a child enrolling in a coaching centre and a child sitting out a year.

The Machine

Over three weeks in August 2026, we tracked the network behind the ad that caught Ayman's mother. What we found was not a single bad actor with a laptop. It was a repeating infrastructure — dozens of Facebook pages, cycling through names like "Islami Online 3.0," "Loan Seba 51," "City Loan Help Service," and "Trusted Islami Loan," all running paid advertisements on Meta's platform, all using the same playbook, and all invisible to the people whose money they took until it was too late.

The pages borrow the logos of real banks. They splice together old footage of recognisable public figures — religious scholars, news anchors, tech influencers — and re-edit it to sound like an endorsement. Some of the videos use deepfake lip-sync. The targeting is precise: the captions are seeded with keywords like "halal," "mudaraba," "no-interest," "easy loan" — terms calibrated to reach people who are financially distressed and religiously observant.

On any given day during our monitoring period, between 50 and 60 of these ads were active simultaneously. Remove one page and a new one appears within hours under a different name. The Meta Ad Library, the company's public transparency tool, confirmed the pattern: the same operators keep re-registering.

The mechanics of the scam itself are blunt. A user responds to the ad through Messenger. The page asks for a photograph of the user's National Identity Card — the NID, Bangladesh's primary government-issued ID, which carries a name, photo, date of birth, and a unique number. The operators then present a forged "loan approval" letter showing an amount between 5,000 and 700,000 taka, and demand a processing fee of 5 to 10 percent. The user pays through bKash or Nagad. Then the page blocks them.

That NID photo does not disappear. Investigators and police officials have linked the harvesting of identity data through Facebook to a parallel ecosystem of illegal loan apps — names like Shathi Loan, PopCash, QuickTaka, EasyTaka, Dhaka Fin Loan — that demand access to a phone's gallery and contact list, and then use personal photos for blackmail when repayment is missed or refused.

The Algorithm's Role

The central question of this investigation is not about the scammers. Scammers exist in every economy. The question is why Meta's platform is so efficient at delivering their message to exactly the right people.

The answer lies in how Meta's ad-delivery algorithm works. The operators do not select individual targets. They do not need to. They post an ad with the right keywords — "halal loan," "collateral-free," "instant approval" — and wait for the first clicks. When an underpaid garment worker in Savar, or a retired schoolteacher in Mymensingh, or a homemaker in Gazipur clicks on one of these ads, the algorithm learns something: this is the audience. It then finds more people who match the same profile — same age bracket, same economic signals, same browsing behaviour — and serves them the same ad, or one from a sister page.

In other words, the platform's own optimisation machinery locates fresh victims and delivers them to the scam.

This is not speculation. It is what Meta's own internal documents describe. A Reuters investigation published in late 2025, based on leaked internal memos, reported that Meta's systems were delivering roughly 15 billion scam ads per day to users globally — an average of about 11 fraudulent ads per person, per day. The same internal memos acknowledged that when a user clicks on a scam, "the automated ad-targeting system floods that user's feed with more scams." The company's own analysis concluded that it was "easier to advertise scams on Meta platforms than Google."

Cristobal Cheyre, an assistant professor of information science at Cornell University who studies targeted advertising, described the dynamic in stark terms after reviewing the Reuters findings.

Meta's ad tools, he said, "have also become potent instruments for scammers, enabling them to identify and repeatedly target vulnerable users with precision."
In Bangladesh, where Facebook has roughly 75 million users — about 41 percent of the population — and where, for many first-time internet users, Facebook is the internet, the exposure is immense.

"The Oversight Is Extremely Weak"

We called Miraj Ahmed Chowdhury, the managing director of Digitally Right, a Dhaka-based organisation that works on digital rights and platform accountability, and laid out the evidence: the pages, the ad-library records, the victim's account.

His response was immediate: the loan ads are illegal under Bangladeshi law, which means the advertisements themselves violate Meta's own policies against promoting unlawful financial products. But the ads keep running.
"Their oversight is extremely weak," Chowdhury told us. "This is a big problem, because through this, countless people are being defrauded. And the advertising revenue from these ads — Meta earns that. So the responsibility for profiting from fraud falls on them, too."

He drew a wider frame. These scams, he said, are not new, and not small. They are often linked to transnational networks operating from the Cambodia-Myanmar border corridor, the same infrastructure identified in United Nations reports on Southeast Asian cyber-crime. The operators use local agents to open mobile financial-service accounts under fake identities, making the money trail hard to follow.
"The kind of institutional initiative needed to tackle these infrastructures — we don't really see it," Chowdhury said. "And always, the people who suffer the most are the poorest."

The Banks Know. The Regulator Knows.

To test how the scam intersects with the formal banking system, we showed the fake advertisements — including one that used Sonali Bank's name and logo to advertise a "nano loan" — to Md. Rezaul Karim, a deputy managing director at Sonali Bank, one of Bangladesh's largest state-owned banks. He did not hesitate. "This is completely fake," Karim said. "We have our own app for nano loans. Any promotion of our products through a third-party app or page is baseless, fraudulent, and the work of a scam syndicate."

He urged the public to avoid the pages and called for legal action. "If you don't bring these fraudsters to justice, the public will keep falling into these traps. A GD should be filed, followed by a formal case. Swift punitive action is essential."

When we contacted Arif Hossain Khan, a spokesperson for Bangladesh Bank, the country's central bank, he confirmed that the institution has been aware of the problem "for a long time." The Bangladesh Financial Intelligence Unit (BFIU) and the Criminal Investigation Department (CID) are working jointly on it, he said. When the investigation requires the central bank's cooperation, "Bangladesh Bank cooperates immediately."

But he also said something revealing: "There's not much for us to do on this end." The regulatory apparatus sees the scam primarily as a law-enforcement matter — not as a failure of platform governance. That gap — between a regulator who sees the problem but considers it someone else's jurisdiction, and a platform that profits from the ads but treats enforcement as a game of whack-a-mole — is where the fraud lives.

The Numbers

The scale of online financial fraud in Bangladesh is difficult to measure precisely, because most victims never report. But the fragments that do surface suggest an enormous problem.

The Bangladesh Financial Intelligence Unit recently shut down more than 20,000 mobile financial-service accounts linked to scams, gambling, and illicit transactions. Bangladesh's home ministry has estimated that the country lost 21,000 crore taka — roughly $1.75 billion — to various forms of financial fraud between 2006 and 2021. An investigation by Prothom Alo, one of Bangladesh's largest newspapers, identified at least 30 illegal loan apps operating in the country. And in July 2026, the Asian Development Bank issued a public alert warning Bangladeshis that scammers were using the ADB's name and logo on fake Facebook pages to solicit fees for nonexistent loans.

Globally, Meta's relationship with scam advertising has drawn increasing scrutiny. A European Digital Media Observatory report found that deepfake scam ads — including fake financial products — were running across EU countries on Meta's platforms, often in multiple languages. The Open Rights Group, a UK-based advocacy organisation, published a report documenting how Meta's profiling and ad-targeting tools have been used by bad actors to spread fraud, among other harms.

And Meta's own internal estimates, as reported by Reuters, suggest that the company books approximately $7 billion a year in revenue from fraudulent advertising — while estimating that the maximum it would pay in global fines is roughly $1 billion. The arithmetic, from the company's perspective, apparently works.

What the Platform Won't Say

We did not receive a response from Meta to specific questions about the loan-scam advertisements documented in this investigation.

The company has previously stated that it invests in scam prevention and removes fraudulent ads and pages when they are reported. But the internal documents reported by Reuters tell a different

story: Meta had developed what staffers called a “playbook” to manage external pressure on scam enforcement — and its own experiments showed that when it tightened advertiser verification in one country (Taiwan), its algorithms simply rerouted the fraudulent ads to users in other markets.
“Unless advertiser verification was enforced globally,” Meta’s own staffers wrote in an internal analysis, the company “wouldn’t so much be fighting scams as relocating them.”

Bangladesh, with its 75 million Facebook users and limited digital-literacy infrastructure, is precisely the kind of market that absorbs the relocated harm.

After

A few days after his mother was scammed, Ayman Mahmud went through her phone. He found the website she had visited. He looked at the video. It took him less than a minute to see that the footage of Shaikh Ahmadullah was synthetic — the lip movements were off, the audio was stitched. It had not come from the scholar’s official foundation. It had come from a page that no longer existed.

Three thousand taka. A spoofed SMS. A fake website. An AI-generated video. And underneath all of it, an algorithm that found Ayman’s mother — a woman going through a financial rough patch, who trusted a religious leader, who clicked on a blue link — and decided she was exactly the kind of person who should see more ads like that one.
That algorithm is still running.

NB: If you have been a victim of an online loan scam, you can report it to the CID Cyber Crime Unit or call the national helpline at 999.